CHINA, JAPAN, AND KOREA

NAVAL POWER played an important part in East Asian warfare, as a sometimes crucial ancillary to land campaigns. As early as the 3rd century CE, the battle of Red Cliffs established a consistent theme in Chinese history: the ability of the southern Chinese to defend themselves against invaders from the north by resort to river and sea warfare. This pattern was repeated against the Jurchen at Tangdao and initially against the Mongols in the 13th century. The Mongol Yuan dynasty eventually conquered the Song after adapting to naval warfare. The period of Yuan rule was framed by two naval battles: a Mongol victory at Yamen in 1279 and a defeat at Lake Poyang in 1363. Sea battles were also crucial in the histories of Korea and Japan. The Japanese failed to extend their influence into Korea in the 7th century, repulsed by the Chinese navy, and the Mongols made equally unsuccessful attempts to invade Japan. The outcome of Japan's civil wars was affected by fighting on water, notably at Dan-no-Ura in 1185.

SILLA–BAEKJE WARS

BAEKGANG



Date August 27–28, 663
Forces Japanese: 800 ships; Chinese: 170 ships
Losses Japanese: 400 ships, Chinese: unknown

Location Geum River, Korea

China's Tang dynasty occupied the Baekje kingdom of southern Korea in alliance with another Korean kingdom, Silla. Japan's Yamato government sent a fleet and an army of more than 40,000 men to aid Baekje forces under siege at Churyu. They intended to ferry the troops up the Geum River, but found the river blocked by a Chinese fleet. The Chinese were heavily outnumbered but their ships held a disciplined line from bank to bank. In two days of repeated attacks the Japanese failed to break through. Seeing the Japanese tired and disorganized, the Chinese then launched a counterattack, outflanking and encircling the Japanese fleet. Many of the Japanese ships were burned and thousands of soldiers drowned. Baekje was defeated and, with Chinese aid, the Silla kingdom unified Korea.

JURCHEN–SONG WARS

TANGDAO



Date November 16, 1161
Forces Song: 120 ships; Jurchen: 600 ships
Losses Unknown

Location Near Shandong peninsula, East China Sea

In 1161 the Jurchen of northern China were attempting to conquer southern China, ruled by the Song dynasty. An invasion force of warships and troop transports was intercepted by the Song navy among the islands of the East China Sea. The Song had developed paddle-wheel craft powered by treadmills, which moved swiftly into the attack. On their decks they had trebuchets that hurled primitive incendiary bombs to explode on the wooden enemy ships. Soon much of the Jurchen armada was ablaze. Its commander, Zheng Jia, jumped into the sea and was drowned. The following month another Jurchen fleet was defeated by the Song at the battle of Caishi on the Yangtze River, ensuring the survival of the southern Song as an independent state for another century.

